

KUSH THAKER

kushthaker@gmail.com • Rome, Italy

I design the policy and systems that identify who receives humanitarian aid, and steward how those systems use biometrics and AI responsibly. As a Canadian with five years at the United Nations, I pair engineering depth with the political judgment to move sensitive initiatives through multilateral institutions with competing mandates.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Programme Policy Officer, Identity Management

Nov 2023 – Present

United Nations World Food Programme, Headquarters, Supply Chain Division | Rome, Italy

- **Founded and scaled WFP's enterprise deduplication platform across 15+ countries**, coordinating technical, normative, and private-sector partners to deliver business processes, requirements, and assurance controls that detect duplicate assistance and drive cost efficiencies. Equipped country offices with tools to support case management decisions and strengthened monitoring for bilateral donors.
- **Led WFP's role in the UN80 reform initiative evaluating face recognition for common beneficiary identification**. On mission in Mogadishu, Somalia, secured Humanitarian Country Team approval and EU funding for a common identification approach that strengthens accountability that assistance reaches the intended person, advancing more integrated, people-centered delivery.
- **Stewarded WFP's responsible AI and biometric data governance**, partnering with Programme, Data Privacy, and Legal Offices to apply data protection principles in sensitive uses of personal data. Shaped corporate guidance and carried work into UN80 interagency design for system-wide approach to biometrics.
- **Advanced interoperable identity infrastructure across WFP supply chain and UNHCR systems**, decomposing complex technical and political dependencies into tractable workstreams where competing institutional mandates had stalled progress. Deployed the WFP-UNHCR gateway, extending biometric verification to 10 million shared beneficiaries.

Data Assurance Analyst, Monitoring & Evaluation

Apr 2022 – Oct 2023

United Nations World Food Programme, Uganda Country Office | Kampala, Uganda

- **Established the identity management function in WFP's Uganda Country Office**, supporting assistance to 1.3 million refugees. Coached national and international staff in field offices on data standards and analytics, briefing country leadership, crisis response and risk management units.
- **Built and tested the data pipelines that digitized aid delivery across 75 distribution points**, automatically flagging errors and reconciling transfers, and closed critical internal audit findings on data integrity.
- **Convened a regular technical forum with UNHCR and partner agencies** to put needs-based prioritization into practice across 13 refugee settlements, aligning both agencies' data and processes to prevent exclusion errors, so eligible families kept their assistance.

Junior Professional Consultant

Sep 2021 – Mar 2022

United Nations Association in Canada, International Development and Diplomacy Internship Programme | Remote

- **Led WFP Uganda's 2021 Annual Country Report**, liaising with the country programme management team and Regional Bureau to consolidate inputs from all programme activities into a single corporate account of results and partnerships, delivered on time for WFP's Executive Board reporting cycle.
- **Wrote donor performance reports for USAID, ECHO, FCDO, and CIDCA**, conducting technical analysis of grant outputs and food security outcomes against logframe targets using each agency's reporting templates, and supporting partnership reporting through WFP's COMET and DOTS systems.

Census Enumerator

May – Aug 2021

Statistics Canada | Toronto, Ontario

- **Enumerated households for Canada's 2021 Census**, achieving a 98% response rate across assigned areas through interviews and non-response follow-up, bound by Statistics Act confidentiality.

Product Manager Intern

May – Dec 2018

AppDirect | Montreal, Quebec

- **Drove delivery of a cybersecurity product from requirements to launch**, deploying to 70,000 users in three months to preempt a Windows update risk and protect \$2M in annual recurring revenue.

Product Manager Intern

Sep 2016 – Dec 2017

Influitive Corporation | Toronto, Ontario

- **Developed an agile prioritization framework** linking client revenue, feature requests, and usage metrics to guide product roadmap and sprint decisions.

Database Administrator Intern

Jan – Apr 2016

The Rubicon Project (now Magnite) | San Francisco, California

- **Increased on-premises storage capacity by 63%** through migration of historical datasets to cloud archive storage, optimizing infrastructure costs while maintaining data accessibility.

Marketing Analyst Intern

Sep – Dec 2014

Polar Mobile | Toronto, Ontario

- **Analyzed advertising campaign performance** with SQL and presented findings to Bloomberg, Hearst, and The Globe and Mail on how readers engaged with sponsored content.

Web Development Intern

Jan – Apr 2014

AGF Investments | Toronto, Ontario

- **Developed and maintained web content for financial advisor materials**, managing updates to AGF's advisor-facing web platform to support timely delivery of investment product information.

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Applied Science, Systems Design Engineering

2014 – 2020

University of Waterloo | Ontario, Canada

Coursework: Pattern Recognition, Complex Systems, Human Factors, Decision Optimization

SKILLS & LANGUAGES

Data & Analysis: Python (Jupyter), SQL, Tableau

Policy & Governance: Responsible AI, biometric data governance, data protection, interagency data sharing

Product & Delivery: Agile product ownership, business requirements, user acceptance testing

Platforms & Systems: SCOPE, DataSphere, COMET, AWS, open data collection tools

Languages: English (first official language), Gujarati and Hindi (fluent), French (developing)

TRAINING & RECOGNITION

WFP Innovation Award, People's Choice

2026

Recognized for the Enterprise Deduplication Platform, voted by staff across WFP

Safe and Secure Approaches in Field Environments

2024

Security training for high-risk field deployments | Brindisi, Italy

Digital Transformation Recognition, WFP Uganda Country Office

2023

Recognized at an all-staff ceremony before transfer to headquarters

TD Scholarship for Community Leadership

2013

Selected as one of 20 national recipients of the \$70,000 award